

Behind-the-screen primer for Or'Henn, the Ashen Shepherd. Every contract trap, NPC motive, and the true backstory are stated openly here. Do NOT hand to the player (Mikas). Player-facing cards live in [orbenn-cinderbloom-and-contracts.html](#) and [orbenn-wildshape-codex.html](#).



OR'HENN — THE ASHEN SHEPHERD

DM's behind-the-screen primer · D&D 5e (2024) · Descent into Avernus · PC of "Mikas" · elderly Red Dragonborn druid, Level 11

THE ONE-LINE PITCH. Or'Henn is a dispossessed *keeper*, not a refugee. He was the chief living retainer of an Avernian noble's garden-estate; a demon warband razed it and a barlgura looted his badge-of-office (the staff **Cinderbloom**). He kept his druid magic but lost his *title, authority, and lawful claim*. The whole arc is him clawing back a domain — and the Emporium's devils are happy to sell him the paperwork, each sheet with a hook in it.

1 TRUE BACKSTORY (THE FULL, CANONICAL VERSION)

THE ASHEN GARDEN

Or'Henn was hatched in the **Ashen Garden** — a chartered enclave of living retainers attached to the estate of an Avernian devil noble. The household deliberately kept mortal gardeners, handlers, and scribes alive because **living hands can**

why the enclave existed and why Or'Henn's kind were valuable rather than merely tortured.

THE PREDECESSOR & THE STAFF

His teacher was **an enslaved druid taken from the Material Plane** — dragged to Avernus and put to work. This predecessor taught Or'Henn the **dark magic** of iron, flame, and ash, the **magical** of the underworld's **Rotting** **Land**, and on his passing left Or'Henn **childless** **and** **powerless** **in** **the** **dark**.

The badge of the estate's chief keeper
the symbol of office

containment (conveniently the
Avernus of the garden)

The key to the manager's wards —
opens/commands the estate's defense

the proof of keepership — infernal
law, the law of the land

LOAD-BEARING RULING. Or'Henn **KEEPS HIS DRUIDIC MAGIC WITHOUT THE STAFF.** Wild Shape, spellcasting, Circle features — all his, always. The staff is his *title and inheritance*, not his character sheet. This is deliberate: it preserves his agency and makes recovery a story goal, not a power crutch. Do not let a table read the staff-loss as "the druid is nerfed until he gets it back." He is fully functional; what he lacks is *standing*.

THE RAZING

The estate was destroyed by a **Yeenoghu-aligned warband** — explicitly a **vanguard**, **not the demon lord himself** (demons that die on Avernus reform in the Abyss, so

"Yeenoghu attacked" never means the god in person). Or'Henn fled without the staff. **What he actually lost was not power but position:** his office as chief keeper, his authority over the surviving beasts, and any lawful claim to the Ashen Garden.

TIE-IN TO SESSION 7 (STRONGLY RECOMMENDED). The party just defeated the **YEENOGHU + DUMAL** front in the Demon Zapper climax. Bolt Or'Henn's backstory onto that victory: the warband that razed his estate was *the same demonic incursion the party already broke*. That makes the new PC's grievance and the old party's triumph the same event — instant shared stakes, and it explains why the survivors/loose assets are surfacing *now*. The shield crest (a devil noble house) is the open thread; name it when the party asks, and you can hang the estate's former master off it.

HIS REAL AMBITION

Not vengeance, not going home. Or'Henn wants to **recover Cinderbloom, then settle or weaponize the estate's remaining obligations and build a domain of his**

own. He is an heir chasing an inheritance in a plane that runs on contracts — which is exactly the bait the Emporium dangles. Play him as patient, proprietary, and comfortable with infernal legalism; he is a *native* of Avernus, not a horrified visitor.

2 THE RECOVERY ARC — STRUCTURE & PACING

The staff-recovery questline is a clean **3-beat chase to a boss**, threaded through three of the five contracts. The

other two (II, IV) are optional side-deals for gear and for Asimov's benefit.

ESTATE BOUNDARY SEAL → BLOOD-WAR SALVAGE MANIFEST → BARLGURA
KHARZUG THE ROOT-EATER → THE WEeping FURROW TRENCH → STAFF
GIVEN AS TRIBUTE TO LADY UREXIEL, KEEPER OF THE SCABROUS
MENAGERIE (THE BOSS)

THE BREADCRUMB CHAIN (WHAT
EACH CONTRACT DOES FOR THE
CHASE)

Contract I LEAD the manifest

Recovering the estate's boundary
seal earns an inheritance manifest that *names* the boss
later as the Barlgura of the Scabrous

Contract II

a **1-hour compass** before it burns away. This is the tool that actually points at the staff.

- No honest infernal document gives a distance. The **Weeping Furrow is found by three supernatural signs**, not by "two days east":

- ### SUGGESTED RUN ORDER (3 BEATS)

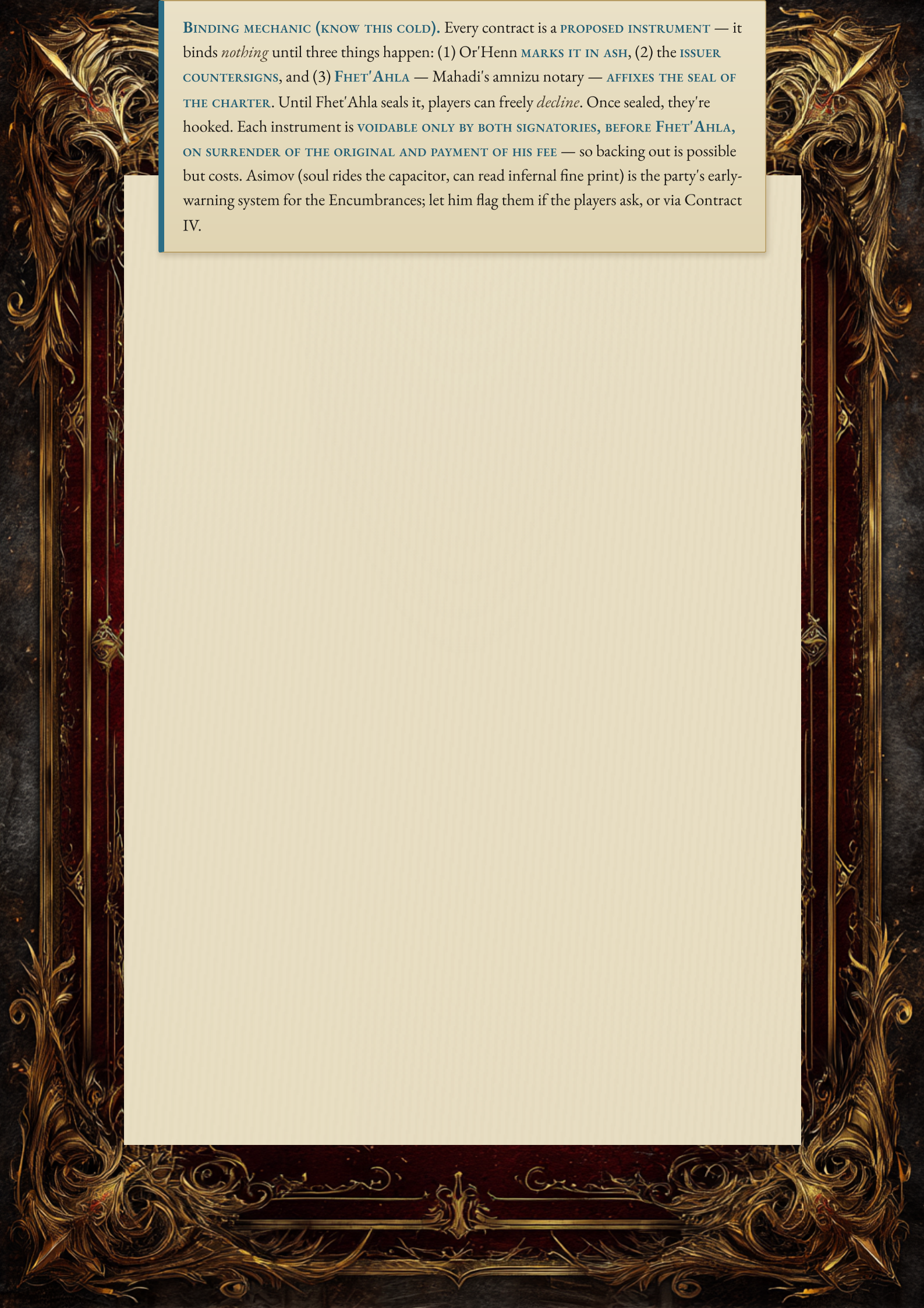
Beat 1 — Contract I (the manifest). Party returns to the ruined estate, recovers the boundary seal, earns the manifest. Reveal: Khazrug + Weeping Furrow. *Trap primed: Or'Henn is now legally the "final acting groundskeeper" (see Encumbrance I).*

Beat 2 — Contract III (the compass), then Contract V (the writ). Bag Morrow for the ashwood-flake compass; take the iron-orchard job for the writ. Now the party has a pointer *and* a legal claim. Confront Kharzug at the Weeping Furrow — recover the staff, or learn it was handed onward to Urexiel.

Beat 3 — Lady Urexriel (the boss). The staff is tribute in her Scabrous Menagerie. Resolve by writ (present the reclamation writ), by bargain, or by fight. **This dovetails into the Mother Ash capstone** — one of the three Green Remnants sits in her menagerie, so beating/dealing-with Urexriel can hand off both the staff and the first upgrade component.

3 THE CONTRACTS — FULL ENCUMBRANCES (THE TRAPS, STATED OPENLY)

"Good news: the Emporium has leads. Bad news: every lead has read the fine print." — Asimov, from inside the soul capacitor.



BINDING MECHANIC (KNOW THIS COLD). Every contract is a **PROPOSED INSTRUMENT** — it binds *nothing* until three things happen: (1) Or'Henn **MARKS IT IN ASH**, (2) the **ISSUER COUNTERSIGNS**, and (3) **FHET' AHLA** — Mahadi's amnizu notary — **AFFIXES THE SEAL OF THE CHARTER**. Until Fhet'Ahla seals it, players can freely *decline*. Once sealed, they're hooked. Each instrument is **VOIDABLE ONLY BY BOTH SIGNATORIES, BEFORE FHET' AHLA, ON SURRENDER OF THE ORIGINAL AND PAYMENT OF HIS FEE** — so backing out is possible but costs. Asimov (soul rides the capacitor, can read infernal fine print) is the party's early-warning system for the Encumbrances; let him flag them if the players ask, or via Contract IV.

NO.	TITLE / ISSUER	CONSIDERATION (WHAT'S PROMISED)	ENCUMBRANCE (THE TRAP)
I	The Gardener's Due <i>Procurator Vhalzareth, Third Infernal Chancery</i>	Recover the estate's brass boundary seal ("substantially free of demonic residue") → an authenticated Blood-War salvage manifest naming Kharzug the Root-Eater as the looter and fixing his deployment at the Weeping Furrow (three signs).	TRAP The manifest is the custody of every uncultured, or improperly buried specimen . Three remain loose. Each infernal dawn a specimen stays uncatalogued adds a breach-mark to the seal; at three marks the Chancery may seize any property recovered under this instrument — including the staff.
II	A Measure of Honest Fire <i>Serephine Coal-Tongue, salamander smith (chartered/elemental instrument)</i>	Infiltrate a rival's warehouse, identify grave-cold iron ingots poisoning her forge, mark them with druidic flame (no theft, no employee slain) → either +1 infernal-brass sheath on one weapon (+1 atk/dmg) or focus (+1 spell attack), or three cinderseed ampoules (thrown <i>entangle</i> , 20-ft, DC 15).	TRAP "No employee slain" excludes contractors, debtors, summoned creatures, animated tools, and anyone retroactively terminated before their recorded death . Every ingot he marks is certified defective ; if one marked ingot later proves sound, he owes a year-and-a-day of furnace service — or three soul coins .
III	The Hound That Remembers <i>Pellucid Jax, beast broker</i>	Capture alive & unmaimed the ember-muzzled hell hound " Morrow " (green-copper collar; ate three customers + one ledger) → the collar's inner plate holds his household crest and the living-ashwood flake compass (bends toward the staff for 1 hour over flame).	TRAP Morrow is filed as an " independent commercial predator ," not Jax's property. Delivery is an unsolicited adoption unless 500 gp is deposited into the collar's escrow before Jax opens it . Unpaid → title to Morrow and every recorded liability of its prior killings vests in Or'Henn .
IV	Articles of Temporary Embodiment <i>Mistress Nymira Quill, night hag (Fhet'Ahla enforces)</i>	Obtain the still-warm shadow of a creature that <i>willingly</i> took an infernal bargain and <i>died regretting it</i> , folded in before the corpse cools → Asimov manifests for 1 hour (own stats, spectral gear); can touch one creature to read the exact text of one contract binding it, and learns one hidden clause in his own confinement instrument .	TRAP A rental, not a resurrection. At hour's end the nearest eligible recipient takes necrotic damage = half the HP Asimov lost during the rental (max 8d10) , ignoring resistance, never below 1 HP. " Eligible " = anyone who knowingly accepted Asimov's healing, inspiration, protection, food, or tactical counsel during the hour .

NO.	TITLE / ISSUER	CONSIDERATION (WHAT'S PROMISED)	ENCUMBRANCE (THE TRAP)
V	The Orchard of Borrowed Names <i>Advocate Malfius</i> <i>Nine-Reeds,</i> <i>clerk under</i> <i>Fhet'Ahla</i>	Cut through a grove of iron trees (feeding on true names) to a buried infernal war machine; retrieve the obsidian coffer from its command seat — don't open it, don't speak your own name inside the grove → a writ of reclamation (honored below pit-fiend rank) naming Cinderbloom Or'Henn's property, seizable from any holder. Malfius attests the staff went to Lady Urexiel.	TRAP Or'Henn's debt, oath, lien, and unfinished punishment. The coffer holds a blank name-substitution writ keyed to the Third Chancery; open it (even by accident) and the first true name released replaces Or'Henn's on every contract he's ever signed. Malfius won't say whose name is inside.

HOW THE TRAPS INTERLOCK (THE ELEGANT PART). Encumbrance I makes Or'Henn liable for the three loose specimens; Encumbrance V makes him heir to *every* asset/enemy/debt of the estate. Sign both and he has legally adopted the entire wreck of the Ashen Garden — which is *exactly the domain he wants*, just weaponized against him. That's the campaign: he can accept the burdens and become a landed keeper, or spend the arc voiding instruments before Fhet'Ahla. Both are good outcomes; make him choose.

4 THE MOTHER ASH — THE STAFF UPGRADE (CAPSTONE)

VAELISHA, THE MOTHER ASH — THE LAST GREEN OF AVERNUS. Before this plane became the first layer of Hell it was a living world; when it fell, all its nature burned save **ONE TREE**, hidden in a warded hollow and kept barely alive. **EVERY INFERNAL GARDENER'S STAFF — OR'HENN'S AND HIS PREDECESSOR'S ALIKE — WAS CUT FROM HER BOUGHS.** To rekindle Cinderbloom the party gathers what remains of Avernus's nature and feeds it to her; her renewed sap re-infuses the staff.

THE RITE (QUEST)

Collect **three Green Remnants** — the last living scraps of Avernus's nature — then perform an **8-hour infusion rite** at Vaelisha. Suggested remnants:

- the last seed of Idyllglen;
- living moss from a fallen titan's ribs in the Bleeding Wastes;
- a sap-heart cutting held in Lady Urexiel's Scabrous Menagerie — dovetails directly with Contract V and the boss beat, so the same confrontation that recovers the staff can also yield the first upgrade component.

GATING ADVICE. DO NOT OPEN THE MOTHER ASH ARC UNTIL THE STAFF ITSELF IS RECOVERED. Cinderbloom must exist in Or'Henn's hand before it can be Rekindled; recovering it is the emotional payoff of the whole chase, and the upgrade is the *reward beyond the reward*. Sequence: recover staff (Urexiel beat) → then Green Remnants → then Vaelisha rite. The Urexiel Green Remnant is your natural bridge between the two arcs.

CINDERBLOOD REKINDLED
WHAT THE UPGRADE GRANTS

(LEGENDARY)
Keeps every base power, and adds:

UPGRADE	EFFECT
Greenfire Charges	Capacity rises to 14 charges ; regains 2d6 + 4 on a long rest; no longer risks going dark on a 1 (the Mother Ash's sap keeps the ember lit).
Deepwood Casting	Adds to the Rootwright list: Wall of Thorns (5), Sunbeam (6), Fire Storm (7). Cinderheart now deals 4d8 , and against fiends its damage is radiant — burns straight through devilish fire-immunity.
Bloom of the Last Green	Once/day, action: raise a living grove in a 30-ft radius for 1 min (natural difficult terrain). Start of each of your turns: allies within regain 1d8 HP ; any fiend that starts its turn there takes 2d8 radiant . You see/target through it freely.
Warden's Hold	<i>Keeper of Fell Beasts</i> now affects creatures of Int 8 or lower , and you may keep two such creatures charmed at once.

5 NPC ROSTER — MOTIVES & BETRAYAL ANGLES

NPC	ROLE	WHAT THEY WANT	HOW THEY BETRAY / COMPLICATE
Fhet' Ahla	Amnizu notary of Mahadi's charter (the seal on <i>every</i> contract)	Order, fees, and the integrity of his own charter. He is the fulcrum of the whole system — nothing binds or voids without him.	Neutral-but-not-safe: he enforces the letter exactly as written, including the Encumbrances. Voiding costs "his fee" (leave it vague — a favor, a secret, a soul-coin). He can slow-walk a voiding the party urgently needs.
Procurator Vhalzareth	Estate-Reclamation Advocate, Third Infernal Chancery (Contract I)	To re-file the ruined Ashen Garden as a taxable, liability-bearing asset — with a warm body legally on the hook for it.	He wants Or'Henn to <i>be</i> the acting groundskeeper (Encumbrance I) so the Chancery can seize recovered property via breach-marks. He profits whether Or'Henn succeeds or defaults.
Serephine Coal-Tongue	Salamander smith, the Gilded Crucible (Contract II)	To sabotage a rival by having a neutral third party "certify" the rival's iron defective.	Or'Henn is her patsy: his druidic mark <i>is</i> the certification. If any ingot proves sound, the year-service / three-soul-coin penalty falls on him, not her.
Pellucid Jax	Infernal beast broker, Jax's Immaculate Menagerie (Contract III)	To offload a lethal, liability-laden hound ("Morrow") onto someone else while keeping the useful collar-intel as bait.	The 500 gp escrow is a trapdoor: forget it and Or'Henn inherits Morrow <i>and</i> all its prior kills. Jax profits from the adoption either way.
Mistress Nymira Quill	Night hag, broker of posthumous opportunities (Contract IV)	Souls and dependency. She sells Asimov an hour of embodiment because the debt it creates is worth more than the favor.	The injury-transfer clause weaponizes the party's own teamwork against them — anyone Asimov helped becomes the "willing" recipient of up to 8d10 necrotic. She profits from party cohesion.
Advocate Malfius Nine-Reeds	Lesser counsel / clerk under Fhet' Ahla (Contract V) — NOT a second amnizu	To move a dangerous name-substitution device out of the war machine and into a mark's hands, wrapped in a genuinely useful writ.	The writ is real and works — but its inheritance clause and the coffer's blank name-writ are the sting. He declines to name the imprisoned true name. Treat him as a mid-rank fixer who answers upward to Fhet' Ahla.

NPC	ROLE	WHAT THEY WANT	HOW THEY BETRAY / COMPLICATE
Lady Urexiel	Keeper of the Scabrous Menagerie — holds the staff (the boss of the recovery arc)	To keep her collection intact; Cinderbloom was given to her as <i>tribute</i> and a sap-heart Green Remnant sits in her menagerie.	She won't surrender tribute cheaply. Resolve by writ (Contract V), by bargain (offer a specimen, a service, or a rival's head), or by force. She can also be the party's route to the first Green Remnant — leverage, not just a fight.
Kharzug the Root-Eater	Barlurga who looted the staff from the estate (the mid-arc obstacle)	Plunder and survival; he's a Blood-War asset last deployed to the Weeping Furrow. He passed the staff up the chain as tribute.	He no longer has the staff (gave it to Urexiel), so killing him yields intel, not the prize — a deliberate mid-point turn that redirects the party to the real boss.

6 ADJUDICATION NOTES — RUNNING OR'HENN

(A) WILD SHAPE & THE INFERNAL FORM LIST

NON-BEAST FORMS MUST BE **EARNED** INDIVIDUALLY. Or'Henn does NOT auto-gain the Monstrosity/Fiend/Elemental forms in the Wild Shape Codex. Each must be unlocked by studying, defeating, binding, or tending that specific creature. When earned, he gains only its **PHYSICAL SHAPE AND NATURAL ATTACKS** — NO INNATE SPELLCASTING, NO SHAPECHANGER, NO SUMMON, no other magical traits, unless you explicitly grant them. He is a **CIRCLE OF WILDFIRE** druid (RAW cap: CR 1); by your ruling he Wild Shapes as a **BONUS ACTION** into **CR ≤ 2** — Beast and earned-infernal forms alike, synergizing with *Keeper of Fell Beasts*. **CR 3 FORMS STAY LOCKED** (aspirational; the Hell Hound is his signature goal).

(B) CINDERBLOOM BALANCE (VERY RARE, AS TUNED IN REVIEW)

PROPERTY	RULING
Rarity	Very rare (attunement by a druid). Legendary only after the Mother Ash rite.
The +2	+2 to weapon attack/damage <i>and</i> +2 to spell ATTACK rolls only . No save-DC bump (the +2-to-DC version was pulled back; kept in line with the rare Staff of the Woodlands). All staff effects use the wielder's own spell save DC.
Cinderheart	Costs 2 charges (dialed up from 1). 3d8 fire, DC = his spell save DC.
Keeper of Fell Beasts	Costs 4 charges ; only affects creatures of CR ≤ his proficiency bonus ; the target re-saves whenever it takes damage ; 24-hr immunity after it ends.
Recharge	1d6 + 4 on a long rest, only once per 24h . Last charge → d20, on a 1 it goes dark until replanted in fertile soil and watered for 8h.

ASIMOV IS THE PARTY'S OWN FALLEN SOULKNIFE. He DIED AT YEENOGHU'S HANDS in the Session-7 climax, and his soul was taken into the **SOUL CAPACITOR** — a bounty-hunter's soul-vessel governed by the **SOUL COUNCIL**. His soul occupies it now **IN PLACE OF RASHEEM** — the **PREVIOUS OCCUPANT**, and the one who **FED ASIMOV HIS BOUNTIES** back when Asimov was the living hunter. The role runs in a chain: the trapped soul relays bounties to a living bounty hunter, and when that hunter dies they take the occupant's place. Asimov's death to Yeenoghu is why the vessel holds him now and not Rasheem — and why Asimov relays to the party exactly as Rasheem once did to him. **THE SOUL COUNCIL HAS GIVEN ASIMOV ONE WEEK TO FIND ANOTHER BOUNTY HUNTER** — that ticking clock is why he relays the **SOUL-BOUNTIES** and why the party needs **OR'HENN**. From inside the vessel he can **READ INFERNAL FINE PRINT**: mechanically he's the party's rules-lawyer against the Encumbrances (let him warn players who consult him), and **BOUNTY IV (ARTICLES OF TEMPORARY EMBODIMENT)** is his showcase — an hour of embodiment that reads the exact text of a contract binding a creature *and* exposes one hidden clause of his own confinement. **CONTINUITY**: the party knew Asimov; **OR'HENN NEVER DID** — Or'Henn is the fresh recruit, met at the Emporium as a post-ravager refugee.

7 THREADS & FORESHADOWING

THE COFFER'S IMPRISONED TRUE NAME (CONTRACT V) — DM DECIDES WHOSE

The blank name-substitution writ inside the obsidian coffer holds one

imprisoned true name; Malfius won't say whose. Pick one and seed it:

OPTION A — OR'HENN'S DEAD MASTER. The devil noble who owned the Ashen Garden. Releasing his name onto Or'Henn's contracts makes Or'Henn *legally become his former owner* — inheriting the estate's enemies in the most literal, horrifying way. Ties the whole arc into a single knot.

OPTION B — THE ENSLAVED PREDECESSOR DRUID. The Material-Plane druid who taught Or'Henn and left him the staff. A mercy-and-horror choice: freeing the name could liberate a long-tormented soul — or overwrite Or'Henn with a broken one. Emotional, personal.

OPTION C — A YEENOGHU-FRONT DEMON LIEUTENANT. The named commander of the warband that razed the estate (and the Session-7 front). Releasing it swaps Or'Henn's identity for a wanted demon's — every devil debt in Avernus suddenly hunts *him*. Highest-stakes, most explosive.

...two' and into one. The other two' are yours, to design (candidates something that may or may not exist). Wilds here: a Green Remnant's command that keeps the clock ticking, such that the sun does ticks the clock on the seal.

HOOKS TOWARD THE NEXT ARC — BEL'S FORGE

Next destination is **Bel's Forge** (*session-6-bels-forge-primer.md*). Bridges: (1) the

in mind war machine is too large
Forge made — trace its maker's mark to Bel's Forge, and the machine ID and the words indicate the back-point toward Bel's Forge. *or* — a Green Remnant or the Mother of the Great hollow can sit along the road to Bel's Forge.

Use the staff-recovery arc as the connective tissue between the closed Dumal/Yeenoghu arc and Bel's Forge.



Sources of truth: orbenn-session-digest.md (canon), orbenn-cinderbloom-and-contracts.html (item + contract cards, Encumbrances extracted above), orbenn-wildshape-codex.html (form list & Wild Shape rulings). This primer contradicts none of them; where the digest and the HTML cards differ, the HTML cards are canonical. DM-only — do not print for the player.